Appendix C
Insight Interview Transcripts

ISAAC'S INTERVIEW | HALL OF RESIDENCE 4 @ NTU

Age:

Isaac: 24.

Living Arrangement: (eg. University Dorm, Co-living suite, Shared HDB/Condo:

Isaac: University dorm. Roomates with Mark.

Including yourself, how many people live in your shared unit?

Isaac: 2 of us.

Would you say you are close friends, acquaintances, strangers, or a mix?

Isaac: We were strangers who met online.

What apps or methods do you currently use to talk to each other and split costs? (e.g., WhatsApp, Splitwise, physical notes).

Isaac: For communication, we mainly just use Whatsapp, and for the bills and stuff we try to collate them on an app called tricount or we just leave the bill slips on each other's desks.

"Could you walk me through a typical week in your household in terms of 'admin' tasks? This might include things like paying bills, cleaning common areas, or managing shared supplies."

Isaac: I don't really have a fixed timing where I check on admin stuff but I'm quite an organised person and I like staying organised. So maybe at least once a week, I'll open up the tricount to key in groceries like toilet paper, dish soap, laundry pods and stuff that I buy. And if there are any utility bills I just key them in.

I usually just take a screenshot [of the tricount], send it to our Whatsapp group and wait for him to acknowledge it. We don't really have a formal system, so it's basically whoever notices it's empty first buys it and then tries to remember to add it to the tricount.

"How do you usually find out that something in the house needs your attention?"

Isaac: Like when things are running out or chores need to be done? Honestly, we just go with the flow. I can walk out of my room and see the trash overflowing, or I find out we're out of detergent just as I try to load the washing machine with my clothes. There isn't really a plan.

Yes, it's quite reactive sometimes, like we just find out things that we ran out of in the moment, or we knew beforehand it was running out but neither of us went out to replenish them.

"Is there a specific 'go-to' place where house rules or past records are kept, or is the process more informal?"

Isaac: Not really. I think when we first moved in years ago, we had a pdf of house rules and guest policies, but it wasn't very thorough and it's been months since I last saw it. We have some agreements here and there in our Whatsapp chat. I usually just search up like for instance, "air-con" in our Whatsapp chat to refer back to how we agreed to split the air-con.

[When prompted about whether it was tedious] I wouldn't say it's tedious, but I guess it takes a while to find that message buried in the chat history. [When you search "air-con" in our chat] There's like a whole bunch of messages about someone being too cold so I have to scroll up far enough to find it.

"If you needed to check a specific agreement or rule right now, how would you go about finding that?"

Isaac: As I mentioned, I'll go through the "Media and Links" section of our Whatsapp chat to find it. There are times I can't find the bill I'm looking for when I'm trying to check if he has paid or not because I don't really "star" those kind of messages. I also don't remember which link it's under so at that point I just give up and send him a text to ask what we agreed on or whether he paid already.

I don't really hate it but I think sometimes it can be a bit awkward. Like for instance, he uses the aircon a lot more than I do so sometimes I don't feel our initial 50-50 split would be fair but I don't really bring it up.

"Could you tell me about how you keep track of important household updates or shared announcements?"

Isaac: Yeah. Again just mainly Whatsapp. Besides that, we sometimes just leave receipts for shared groceries or bill slips on each other's desks. Sometimes we don't even split the cost for shared household stuff because we lost the receipt or just didn't write it down.

"How do you ensure everyone stays on the same page regarding these updates?"

Isaac: So for our house rules or things that we agree on for the month, I usually pin them in the chat.

I think it's convenient. Not much issues here.

"Have there been times when information was missed or misunderstood? What happened in that situation?"

Isaac: Can it be anything? Yeah, last month, I messaged Mark that I'd be hosting a study group on Friday. But I think he missed it because he muted the chat. So while I had some groupmates over, he walked into the living room in his boxers. Yeah it was very awkward. I think he genuinely didn't see the message and it got buried in our chat.

"In your experience, what makes a particular method of communication (like a group chat) 'easy' or 'hard' to use for household tasks?"

Isaac: It's very easy in the sense that it's very quick and convenient to send a text and have it on a record rather than relying on memory from face-to-face conversations. But at the same time, it can be hard to manage when there's things that I want to nitpick on but I don't want to make things awkward.

"Following up with others about chores or payments can sometimes feel different than a casual chat. Could you describe a recent time you had to follow up with a housemate about a shared responsibility?"

Isaac: Yeah. I've had to remind Mark to pay his share of the wifi bill for the 3rd time recently. I actually saw him in the kitchen, but I didn't want to bring it up face-to-face because we were going to have dinner together and I didn't want to ruin the vibe. I just waited until after dinner when I got back to my room and just sent him a text.

"What was the process of sending that follow-up like for you?"

Isaac: Since it's been 3 times already, I honestly debated how I should phrase the message. I was annoyed but I didn't want to come off as rude, I think I spent like 10 minutes thinking about what to write. I just ended up adding an emoji to not come off so serious.

"How do you distinguish between a 'routine check-in' and what might be perceived as 'nagging'?"

Isaac: I don't know if he feels like I'm nagging at him, but to me it's nagging the moment I have to ask him twice. First time is a reminder but any more than that feels like I'm a parent. I don't enjoy it.

"How does the frequency of these types of messages affect the general mood or atmosphere in your home?"

Isaac: I don't bear a grudge towards him or anything. I think at most I just get annoyed in the moment the same pattern happens, or there's some underlying tension when I notice that something running out hasn't been refilled yet for a while, almost like he's waiting for me to buy it.

"Everyone has different expectations for shared spaces. How does your household navigate situations where standards for chores or contributions might differ?"

Isaac: I don't think we do it very well. I mean, personally, I like to keep things clean. But I think my threshold for a clean kitchen is much lower than Mark's. I end up cleaning his oil splatters and wipe down the kitchen grills.

No I don't tell him. I think it's easier to just clean it than to start a conversation about it.

"If you ever feel that the division of labor or chores is imbalanced, how do you go about verifying that?"

Isaac: I can't say for sure it's imbalanced, it might just be subjective. I *feel* like I take the trash out 90% of the time, but maybe he feels the same way about the bathroom. We don't really have a log apart from just "This week, you clean the kitchen and I clean the bathroom" rotating weekly. But it's my word against his in practice. I can't be certain that he's already cleaned the kitchen and we just have different standards of clean, or if he hasn't cleaned it, or if he just hasn't gotten around to cleaning it yet but is going to.

"What would give you more peace of mind regarding how everyone is contributing to the household?"

Isaac: Probably more visibility or accountability. Doesn't have to be so rigid or cold, just a neutral record to keep track of contributions, be it financially or labour-wise, so there's a clearer view of fairness.

"What methods do you prefer using to resolve these differences? (eg. direct F2F conversation, calling, texting in a group chat)

Isaac: Actually, I'd say I'd prefer F2F because it's more natural, but in reality, I use text because it's a buffer. It's less awkward to bring up. But yeah, it might be less effective because it's easier to miss messages.

When you sit down to handle a housing-related admin task, like paying bills or checking schedules, could you describe the setting you are typically in?

Isaac: I'm almost always at my desktop in my room. I never use my phone for work-related or admin stuff, the screen is too small and I just prefer using a bigger monitor for all my work.

Actually, now that you mention it, I do refer back and forth between tricount and screenshots in my gallery and my excel sheet on my desktop to record my spendings.

"What devices are you using, and why do you choose those specific tools for those tasks?"

Answered. Skipped.

"If you could have any piece of household information instantly visible in a common area or at your desk, what would be the most valuable for you to see?"

Isaac: I think a ledger or chart of sorts that records down what's going on in the house today (friends coming over, etc). Maybe a checklist that clarifies who is on what housekeeping duty this week. Also to keep track of financial contributions to shared household groceries and payment of bills.

"How would you feel if household reminders were automated by a system rather than sent by a person? What pros or cons do you see in that approach?"

Isaac: I don't know how much of it can be automated, especially if agreements change on the fly like how we don't always split the air-con 50-50 every month, some months we split 70-30 because he acknowledges that he used it more than I did. But if there were some aspects that were automated or in one interface, it could be useful. At least I don't need to bring up awkward conversations.

Cons? Probably the fact that it's cold and robotic. Might take some time to develop the habit to use it in the first place but for this kind of admin task, I think it's reasonable. I'll take it over being passive-aggressive.

MARK'S INTERVIEW | HALL OF RESIDENCE 4 @ NTU

Age

Mark: 22.

Living Arrangement: (eg. University Dorm, Co-living suite, Shared HDB/Condo)

Mark: University dorm, double room with Isaac.

Including yourself, how many people live in your shared unit?

Mark: 2 of us, me and Isaac.

Would you say you are close friends, acquaintances, strangers, or a mix?

Mark: We didn't know each other before, but we're chill now.

What apps or methods do you currently use to talk to each other and split costs? (e.g., WhatsApp, Splitwise, physical notes).

Mark: We use Whatsapp to communicate. I don't think we track stuff together but on my end I use excel sheets to track my spendings.

"Could you walk me through a typical week in your household in terms of 'admin' tasks? This might include things like paying bills, cleaning common areas, or managing shared supplies."

Mark: Uh, a typical week? Honestly, I don't think about it too much. Isaac is way more on top of that stuff than I am. I usually just wait for him to ping me (on WhatsApp) if I forget anything.

He usually sends me a screenshot of what I owe. For cleaning, we have a rough idea, like, I'll do the bathroom one week, he does the kitchen. But if it looks okay, I might skip a few days. I'm pretty busy with school, so if I don't see a reminder, it kind of just slips my mind.

"How do you usually find out that something in the house needs your attention?"

Mark: Usually when Isaac tells me [laughs]. Or if I can't find something, like if the toilet paper is totally gone. I'm not the type to check the 'stock' level of dish soap every day. If it's there, it's there. If it's not, then I realise, 'Oh, okay, I should probably go down to Prime and grab some.'

"Is there a specific 'go-to' place where house rules or past records are kept, or is the process more informal?"

Mark: I think there was a PDF somewhere? I probably saw it when I first moved in, but I don't know where it is now. If I'm unsure about something, I just ask Isaac. We have a group chat, but I have it muted most of the time because I get too many notifications. I think he tells me most important stuff in person anyway."

"If you needed to check a specific agreement or rule right now, how would you go about finding that?"

Mark: I'd probably just ask Isaac. It's way faster than searching through our WhatsApp messages. I know he keeps track of the air-con stuff and the bills in some spreadsheet or app.

I didn't really think about it, it's just easier to rely on him since he's already doing it. I hope it's not annoying for him, but I don't really scroll through our chat to find stuff like that.

"Could you tell me about how you keep track of important household updates or shared announcements?"

Mark: WhatsApp, mainly. But like I said, I mute it. If I see 20+ messages, I just leave it on greytick without looking. I've definitely missed things because of that.

"How do you ensure everyone stays on the same page regarding these updates?"

Mark: Isaac pins stuff (updates), which is helpful I guess. But if I'm on my phone, I'm usually just checking my own DMs. I don't really go into the 'Pin' section of our house chat unless I'm specifically looking for the Wi-Fi password or to report maintenance issues.

"Have there been times when information was missed or misunderstood? What happened in that situation?"

Mark: Yeah, there was that one day... [laughs awkwardly]. I completely missed out a text about him having a study group over. That day I just finished a gym session and walked into the living room in my boxers to get water. There were like four girls there. It was super embarrassing. I felt bad, but also, it's like my house too, you know? If there was a more visible notice maybe I would've remembered, but I just lost the text in the flood and forgot about it."

"In your experience, what makes a particular method of communication (like a group chat) 'easy' or 'hard' to use for household tasks?"

Mark: I find it difficult to track stuff with a group chat, but that could be just me. I'm not very good at opening messages or replying to people, mainly because I see it as all "work stuff" and I'm just trying to relax when I'm on my phone. I prefer face-to-face.conversations.

"Following up with others about chores or payments can sometimes feel different than a casual chat. Could you describe a recent time you had to follow up with a housemate about a shared responsibility?"

Mark: I don't really follow up with Isaac, he's usually the one following up with me I think. Uh, I think he reminded me one time about the Wi-Fi bill recently. I saw the text, but I was in the middle of a game, so I thought, 'I'll do it later.' Then I forgot. He had to ask me again a few days later. I don't mind him asking, but I can tell he gets a bit stiff about it and I feel bad.

"What was the process of sending that follow-up like for you?"

Mark : When I send him money for the bills, I just 'thumbs up' his message. I don't really draft my own message. I can see why I should do that though, it'll be much clearer to keep track of things.

"How do you distinguish between a 'routine check-in' and what might be perceived as 'nagging'?"

Mark: We don't really have a routine check-in per say, but sometimes we won't talk much or these kinds of admin conversations dominate our interactions. It feels a bit transactional sometimes. Like, we're roommates, we should be hanging out, but half our texts are just like, 'You owe me $12' or, 'Can you clean the sink?' I get it but it puts down the vibe sometimes.

"How does the frequency of these types of messages affect the general mood or atmosphere in your home?"

Mark: To be honest, most of the time when I get a text about something I *know* I need to do, but just haven't done yet, I get a bit annoyed. Like, I know the trash is full. I was just about to get to doing it. But getting a text about it just as I plan to do it that day just kills my mood and motivation sometimes.

"Everyone has different expectations for shared spaces. How does your household navigate situations where standards for chores or contributions might differ?"

Mark: I think I'm more chill about cleanliness. If there's a bit of clutter on the stove, it doesn't bother me, I'll clean it when I do big cooks and meal preps on Sundays. I know Isaac seems to want it cleaned every day. He doesn't say anything, but I see him cleaning up after me sometimes. I'm like, 'I'll do that, don't worry,' but he does it anyway. We haven't really talked about where the 'line' is for cleanliness.

"If you ever feel that the division of labor or chores is imbalanced, how do you go about verifying that?"

Mark: I don't verify it. I just assume it's fine. If he's unhappy, he'll probably say something. But for contributions wise, I tend to use the aircon a lot more than he does especially during the day, so on my end I offer to split the bill 70-30 instead of our usual 50-50 so it's more fair that way.

"What would give you more peace of mind regarding how everyone is contributing to the household?"

Mark: I find it very difficult for me to remember to do or much less record down things to do, even chores. So for me I think a system that shows a clear "status" of the state of the house and what needs to be done would be helpful. If I see that I'm like, "behind" on chores, I'll probably just do them to keep the peace.

"What methods do you prefer using to resolve these differences? (eg. direct F2F conversation, calling, texting in a group chat)

Mark: Isaac can get kind of stiff sometimes. I'm quite scared I made him annoyed by forgetting something. I'll prefer to text because it's less confrontational.

When you sit down to handle a housing-related admin task, like paying bills or checking schedules, could you describe the setting you are typically in?

Mark: I'll usually do admin work when I'm in a busy environment, like in a lecture or the library. I focus better when I'm multitasking.

"What devices are you using, and why do you choose those specific tools for those tasks?"

Mark: Laptop. I don't use my phone for work unless it's Whatsapp. I game on my phone.

"If you could have any piece of household information instantly visible in a common area or at your desk, what would be the most valuable for you to see?"

Mark: Probably a to-do-list for the week for me to track my individual commitments and shared responsibilities that I need constant reminders for. Maybe some sort of whiteboard or shared calendar.

"How would you feel if household reminders were automated by a system rather than sent by a person? What pros or cons do you see in that approach?"

Mark: I'd actually prefer that. It's less personal. If it's an app telling me like 'Hey, pay your bill,' I won't feel like Isaac will get annoyed at me. I'll just feel like the bill is due. But there's a chance I might just ignore the app notifications the same way I ignore WhatsApp.

XINGCHEN'S INTERVIEW | LIVING OUTSIDE OF @NUS CAMPUS

Age:
20

Living Arrangement: (eg. University Dorm, Co-living suite, Shared HDB/Condo:
Co-living outside of campus

Including yourself, how many people live in your shared unit?
4

Would you say you are close friends, acquaintances, strangers, or a mix?
Strangers — maybe even one "enemy."

What apps or methods do you currently use to talk to each other and split costs? (e.g., WhatsApp, Splitwise, physical notes).
Wechat.
.

"Could you walk me through a typical week in your household in terms of 'admin' tasks? This might include things like paying bills, cleaning common areas, or managing shared supplies."
We don't use a shared notebook or paper system — everyone keeps their own notes and handles their own stuff. Cleaning is mainly about the bathroom (that "enemy" complains there's too much hair), but we also have a cleaner/auntie who comes.
For admin matters, we usually message one specific person who acts as the "coordinator," using WeChat and PayNow.

"How do you usually find out that something in the house needs your attention?"
Only when it directly affects me — like when the electricity runs out. Otherwise, I mostly focus on my own things.

"Is there a specific 'go-to' place where house rules or past records are kept, or is the process more informal?"
It's pretty informal. Some things get stated in the group chat only when someone has really had enough. Typical topics are hygiene/cleanliness and noise (e.g., "please don't be too loud"). If someone notices an issue, they'll just mention it.

"If you needed to check a specific agreement or rule right now, how would you go about finding that?"
Usually only when things reach a breaking point — then I'd look back through the chat history.

"Could you tell me about how you keep track of important household updates or shared announcements?"
We basically wait for one person (the landlord) to notify us, usually via WeChat.

"How do you ensure everyone stays on the same page regarding these updates?"
People reply in the WeChat group chat to acknowledge it.

"Have there been times when information was missed or misunderstood? What happened in that situation?"
Missed: it's usually fine — not a big deal.
Misunderstood: not really.

"In your experience, what makes a particular method of communication (like a group chat) 'easy' or 'hard' to use for household tasks?"
It's not really about the communication tool — it's about communication itself. Ideally, everyone just quietly does their own responsibilities and keeps their own space in good shape.

"Following up with others about chores or payments can sometimes feel different than a casual chat. Could you describe a recent time you had to follow up with a housemate about a shared responsibility?"

No — we basically each handle our own things.

"What was the process of sending that follow-up like for you?"
I will not do such things - we wait for the landlord's messages.

"How do you distinguish between a 'routine check-in' and what might be perceived as 'nagging'?"
Routine check-in: raise a real issue when it comes up, and keep it factual.
Nagging: bringing things up too often, especially if the issues are unreasonable.

"How does the frequency of these types of messages affect the general mood or atmosphere in your home?"
It makes me feel speechless, confused, and annoyed — sometimes even angry. It creates a bit of internal stress.

"Everyone has different expectations for shared spaces. How does your household navigate situations where standards for chores or contributions might differ?"
I lower my standards, let it slide, and don't really manage it. I just wait for the cleaner/auntie to handle it.

"If you ever feel that the division of labor or chores is imbalanced, how do you go about verifying that?"
I wouldn't — I mostly just focus on myself.

"What would give you more peace of mind regarding how everyone is contributing to the household?"
Honestly, I'd just feel like everyone is a really good person.

"What methods do you prefer using to resolve these differences? (eg. direct F2F conversation, calling, texting in a group chat)
Usually texting/typing.

When you sit down to handle a housing-related admin task, like paying bills or checking schedules, could you describe the setting you are typically in?
Wherever I am — when I see a message, I usually forward it right away.

"What devices are you using, and why do you choose those specific tools for those tasks?"

My phone — it’s the most convenient.

"If you could have any piece of household information instantly visible in a common area or at your desk, what would be the most valuable for you to see?"

Whether the doors/windows are properly closed when it rains; water-related status; and reminders to turn off the lights before leaving.

"How would you feel if household reminders were automated by a system rather than sent by a person? What pros or cons do you see in that approach?"I’d actually like it.
Pros: you get reminders; cost-splitting becomes more transparent, fair, and accurate — ideally even detailed down to each room.
Cons: it feels less human, too rigid, and kind of “cold” — a bit like debt collection.

ZIXUAN'S INTERVIEW | UTOWN RESIDENCE @NUS

Age:
20

Living Arrangement: (eg. University Dorm, Co-living suite, Shared HDB/Condo:
UTown Residence, 4-bedroom suite

Including yourself, how many people live in your shared unit?
4

Would you say you are close friends, acquaintances, strangers, or a mix?
Close friends

What apps or methods do you currently use to talk to each other and split costs? (e.g., WhatsApp, Splitwise, physical notes).
Telegram and WeChat.

"Could you walk me through a typical week in your household in terms of 'admin' tasks? This might include things like paying bills, cleaning common areas, or managing shared supplies."
Yingxuan (the RA) usually coordinates admin matters.

"How do you usually find out that something in the house needs your attention?"
When someone brings takeout food with a strong smell (and it affects the shared space).

"Is there a specific 'go-to' place where house rules or past records are kept, or is the process more informal?"
It's relatively formal — rules and records have been stated and kept in the group chat.

"If you needed to check a specific agreement or rule right now, how would you go about finding that?"
I would ask the others if it's okay to do something, usually face-to-face (F2F).

"Could you tell me about how you keep track of important household updates or shared announcements?"
Emails (from UTR and the RA), and the Telegram group chat.

"How do you ensure everyone stays on the same page regarding these updates?"
We check in with each other when we meet in person (F2F).

"Have there been times when information was missed or misunderstood? What happened in that situation?"
No — we haven't really had moments like that. Everyone is quite reasonable.

"In your experience, what makes a particular method of communication (like a group chat) 'easy' or 'hard' to use for household tasks?"
Face-to-face communication is the easiest. For more formal matters, Telegram works well because things are written down.
What's harder is online voice messages, since nothing is properly recorded or easy to refer back to.

"Following up with others about chores or payments can sometimes feel different than a casual chat. Could you describe a recent time you had to follow up with a housemate about a shared responsibility?"
F2F.

"What was the process of sending that follow-up like for you?"
It felt very casual — no pressure, no blame, just simple communication.

"How do you distinguish between a 'routine check-in' and what might be perceived as 'nagging'?"
Routine check-in: normal communication, neutral tone, no emotions attached.
Nagging: repeatedly bringing something up with frustration, especially when nothing changes.

"How does the frequency of these types of messages affect the general mood or atmosphere in your home?"
If it's frequent, it can get a bit irritating — I'd rather not stay in the common area.
If it's infrequent, it's fine, and people usually follow up quickly.

"Everyone has different expectations for shared spaces. How does your household navigate situations where standards for chores or contributions might differ?"
At the start, we set rules (often aligned with school/UTR requirements). Everyone needs to clearly agree on what must be done.
If something isn't met, we discuss and negotiate. For example, if someone dislikes durian, we make sure no one eats strong-smelling food in shared areas.
Even if expectations differ, writing things clearly at the beginning helps reduce conflicts.

"If you ever feel that the division of labor or chores is imbalanced, how do you go about verifying that?"
Not really applicable — there isn't much that requires everyone to clean.

"What would give you more peace of mind regarding how everyone is contributing to the household?"
If I feel others are kind and willing to contribute, I'm also more willing to proactively contribute and set the tone.
But if I'm the only one who cares about something and no one else pays attention, I won't want to keep doing it alone.

"What methods do you prefer using to resolve these differences? (eg. direct F2F conversation, calling, texting in a group chat)
F2F.

When you sit down to handle a housing-related admin task, like paying bills or checking schedules, could you describe the setting you are typically in?
If it's complicated and needs calculation (and isn't clearly agreed on yet), we need a meeting to discuss it together.
If it's simple (and already clearly agreed on), I'll just pay it myself and won't bother others.

"What devices are you using, and why do you choose those specific tools for those tasks?"
Phone and computer — depending on what's more convenient for the task.

"If you could have any piece of household information instantly visible in a common area or at your desk, what would be the most valuable for you to see?"
Honestly, that feels a bit too formal — I wouldn't really prefer it.
But if it existed, it should follow one bottom line: it must not interfere with or disrupt other people's lives.

"How would you feel if household reminders were automated by a system rather than sent by a person? What pros or cons do you see in that approach?"
For money-related matters, a system is better — it feels more official, less emotional, and more trustworthy. If a person sends it, you may still feel the need to check and verify.
For non-money matters (like activities), system reminders might be easier to ignore, because broadcast messages don't feel targeted or specific enough to be taken seriously.